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IARCO RESEARCH PROPOSAL

Full Legal Name: Aadya Chakravorty

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Category: Junior

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Submission Date: September 12, 2026

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Research Topic: Politics, Philosophy (Morality & Ethics), Economics : The Politics of Economic Inequality and Redistribution

Title: When Is Inequality Deserved?: Merit, Opportunity, and Support for Redistribution

Research Problem

Economic inequality is often discussed in terms of the size of differences in income but that's not the only lens through which people judge inequality. In India, the world's most populous country, differences in educational opportunity can give individuals very different starting positions even before they enter higher education or the labour market which directly affects the opportunities available to them later in life. This brings in the debate on how economic outcomes should be judged when people have different starting points. An income difference might be justified when it is attributed to differences in effort or ability while the same difference may seem less justified when it is attributed to unequal opportunities and starting conditions because people already do agree about the fact that inequality exists but differ on causes.

This brings a moral question of deservingness because if higher incomes are seen as the result of individual merit, then inequality might look justified and redistribution less necessary. But if unequal opportunities are seen as contributing to those outcomes, then the same inequality might seem less deserved and redistribution more justified. Existing research has already discussed relationships between meritocratic beliefs, perceptions of fairness and deservingness and support for redistribution. However, less is known about how people respond when the same inequality is explained through merit rather than unequal opportunity.

Research Question: To what extent does attributing economic inequality to merit or unequal opportunity affect perceptions of deservingness and support for income redistribution among young adults in India?

The study looks at whether the reasoning linked to an income difference (specifically merit or unequal opportunity) changes how deserving that difference seems to be. It then considers whether these perceptions are associated with differences in support for income redistribution among young adults in India.

Existing Literature

Research on distributive preferences has consistently shown that people distinguish between inequalities attributed to individual effort and those attributed to luck. Lefgren, Sims, and Stoddard [1] found experimentally that participants considered effort when voting on redistribution while a later voting experiment found lower redistribution when higher wages were determined by talent rather than random

assignment [2]. This implies that perceptions of how income is earned can affect whether unequal outcomes are considered deserving.

More recent research has looked at unequal opportunity more directly with Lekfuangfu, Powdthavee, and Riyanto [3], whose study found that participants redistributed more when opportunities were by luck, while Preuss et al. [4] found that people responded less strongly to unequal opportunities than to more direct forms of luck partly because the effect of opportunity on eventual outcomes is harder to assess. Research has also connected meritocracy and deservingness more directly to redistribution. Tejero-Peregrina et al. [5] found that perceptions of economic inequality influence perceptions of meritocracy which in turn affect support for redistribution while Neerdaels, Blatz, and Crusius [6] found that perceptions of whether wealth is deserved predict redistribution preferences.

Research on inequality of opportunity in India further shows that circumstances such as parental education, household wealth as well as regional location can shape access to education and other basic opportunities [7]. But existing research has generally looked at effort versus luck, unequal opportunity or meritocratic beliefs as separate explanations of inequality. Less is known about how people judge the same inequality when its cause is explicitly attributed either to merit or to unequal opportunity from a comparative lens, especially whether this attribution changes perceived deservingness and support for redistribution, with this study's focus among young adults in India.

Methodology

Quantitative Component: The study will use a randomised between-subjects online experiment involving approximately 300 young adults in India aged 18–25. Participants will be randomly assigned to one of three conditions:

- Merit condition: the income difference is attributed to differences in effort, ability, or achievement.
- Unequal opportunity condition: the same income difference is attributed to differences in educational access and starting conditions.
- Control condition: the income difference is presented without an explanation of its cause.

The income difference and other details of the scenario will be constant across conditions so that only its attributed cause changes. After reading the scenario, participants will rate the deservingness and fairness of the higher income and their support for income redistribution using Likert-scale questions.

The independent variable will be the attribution condition and perceived deservingness/fairness will be taken as a potential mediator and support for redistribution will be the dependent variable. Differences between the three groups will be analysed using one-way ANOVA and appropriate post-hoc comparisons. Regression or mediation analysis will be used to analyse if perceptions of deservingness help account for differences in redistribution support. Basic demographic information, including age, education level and socioeconomic position will also be collected as control variables.

Qualitative Component: A semi-structured interview will be conducted with a smaller subset of participants following the quantitative survey. The interviews will use a set of open-ended questions about how participants interpret the causes of the income difference, whether they consider it deserved or fair, and what factors influenced their judgement. The semi-structured format will keep the main questions consistent across participants while allowing follow-up questions where participants raise relevant points. With participants' consent, interviews will be recorded and transcribed. The responses will then be thematically coded to identify recurring patterns in participants' reasoning around merit, effort, educational opportunity, starting conditions, fairness and deservingness.

9 **Ethical Considerations:** Participation will be voluntary and based on informed consent. Participants will be able to withdraw before submitting their responses and identifying information will not be published in the main dataset. The study will avoid unnecessary questions about participants' personal income or other sensitive information. Participants will be debriefed after the experiment about the purpose of the different explanations of inequality. Data will be stored securely and used only for the proposed research.

Expected Outcomes: The study is expected to find that participants judge the same income inequality differently depending on whether it is attributed to merit or unequal opportunity. Inequality attributed to merit is expected to receive higher deservingness and fairness ratings and lower support for redistribution while inequality attributed to unequal opportunity is expected to have the opposite pattern. The qualitative interviews are expected to provide insight into the reasoning behind these judgements.

Potential Limitations: The use of online convenience sampling may limit how far the findings can be generalised to the wider population of young adults in India. Hypothetical scenarios and self-reported attitudes may also differ from how participants would respond to actual economic inequality. Differences in participants' prior beliefs about merit and opportunity may further influence their responses.

Quality of Writing: The proposal will use clear and concise academic language appropriate for a research audience. Technical terms will be defined where necessary, and the argument will remain 13 focused on the relationship between inequality, deservingness, and redistribution.

IEEE bibliography

[1] L. J. Lefgren, D. P. Sims, and O. B. Stoddard, "Effort, luck, and voting for redistribution," *Journal of Public Economics*, vol. 143, pp. 89–97, 2016, doi: 10.1016/j.jpubeco.2016.08.012.

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[7] S. Menon and S. Madheswaran, "Unequal beginnings: Inequality of opportunity in children's access to education, health, and basic services in India," *The Indian Journal of Labour Economics*, 2026, doi: 10.1007/s41027-026-00626-z.